Signing the pledge

Kennedy's no-invasion pledge was dependent on UN supervision of the withdrawal of the missiles. Castro refused to allow UN inspectors (or rather insisted on comparable inspections of US territory that were unacceptable to Washington). So, formal agreement between Washington and Moscow was never reached and there was no binding commitment on future US presidents. When Kennedy himself addressed members of Brigade 2506 in Miami in December 1962, after their negotiated release from captivity, he was presented with the brigade flag. In a moment of exuberance, he declared: 'I can assure you this flag will be returned to this brigade in a free Havana.'[68]

The Joint Chiefs did not burn their invasion plans in October 1962. Nor did the CIA abandon its attempts to have Fidel Castro murdered. By a grim coincidence, on 22 November 1963 when John F. Kennedy was assassinated in Dallas, a meeting took place in Paris between a Cuban defector, Dr Rolando Cubela, and his CIA case officer, Nester Sanchez.[69] It was one of a series of meetings between the two men. The purpose was to discuss how the CIA would help Cubela's plans to overthrow Castro, including the means by which Fidel would be assassinated (which ironically included a sniper's rifle). Another purpose was for Sanchez to hand over a Paper Mate ballpoint pen, modified (by the CIA's Technical Services Division) to carry a hypodermic needle with which to poison the Cuban Prime Minister.

Fidel had something of a point when, in January 1963, he declared: 'We do not believe in the words of Kennedy; but, moreover, Kennedy has not given any word. And if he gave it, he has already retracted it.'[70] It would seem that if the golden bridge over which Khrushchev retreated on 28 October 1962 was a face-saving formula for the Soviet Premier, it served its purpose. Later, in 1963, the Kennedy administration secretly explored a possible *modus vivendi* with Havana.[71] Yet, in November 1962, US hostility toward Castro remained. If the purpose of the golden bridge in 1962 was to guarantee Cuba's security, the structure looked somewhat dilapidated.